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Whispers
of
Wonders

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Editorial

Dear Readers,

Have you ever wondered why people love telling stories?

Long before there were books, movies, or televisions, people sat together and shared stories. They imagined magical creatures, brave heroes, mysterious forests, and extraordinary adventures. Some stories traveled across oceans and mountains, passed from one generation to another. Others may have been imagined independently by people living thousands of miles apart.

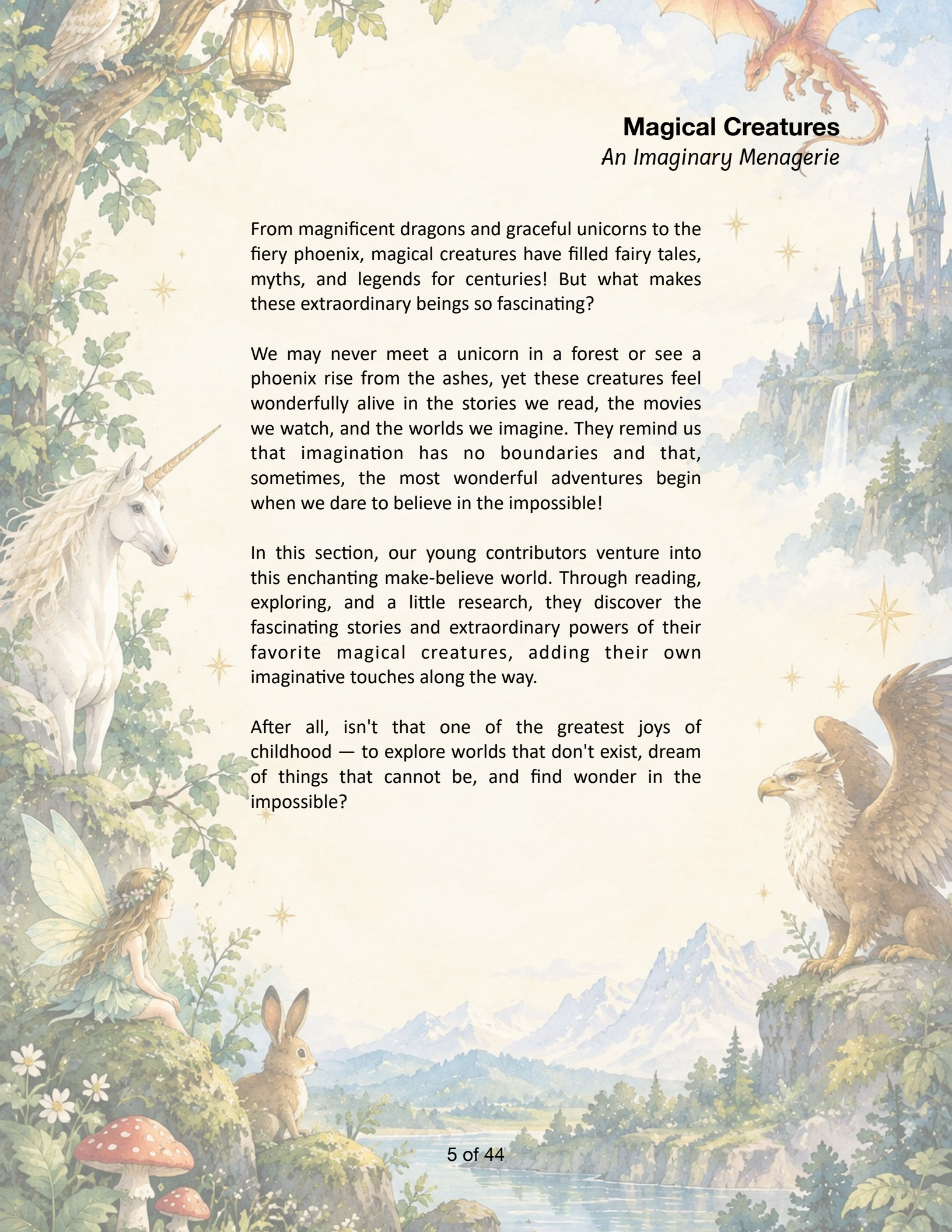
This issue takes us into a world of fairy tales, folklore, and imagination. We meet magical creatures, discover ancient legends, explore how authors find inspiration, and see familiar stories through the curious eyes of our young contributors.

So, as you turn these pages, I invite you to do more than read. Wonder. Question. Imagine. And perhaps invent a story of your own.

Happy reading!

Aadrita Chattopadhyay
Editor-in-Chief

Curiosity Corner



Magical Creatures

An Imaginary Menagerie

From magnificent dragons and graceful unicorns to the fiery phoenix, magical creatures have filled fairy tales, myths, and legends for centuries! But what makes these extraordinary beings so fascinating?

We may never meet a unicorn in a forest or see a phoenix rise from the ashes, yet these creatures feel wonderfully alive in the stories we read, the movies we watch, and the worlds we imagine. They remind us that imagination has no boundaries and that, sometimes, the most wonderful adventures begin when we dare to believe in the impossible!

In this section, our young contributors venture into this enchanting make-believe world. Through reading, exploring, and a little research, they discover the fascinating stories and extraordinary powers of their favorite magical creatures, adding their own imaginative touches along the way.

After all, isn't that one of the greatest joys of childhood — to explore worlds that don't exist, dream of things that cannot be, and find wonder in the impossible?

Fairies

Marie Lukyanenko

I love fairies! Sometimes I imagine myself as a fairy—a gymnastics fairy! I wear a beautiful purple, pink, and rainbow leotard and help children become stronger, healthier, and more flexible. When children exercise and try their best, I leave little surprises under their pillows at night. My most important job is to keep children safe, happy, and healthy!

Mermaids

Aadrita Chattopadhyay

Mermaids are beautiful creatures with the upper body of a human and the tail of a fish. They live deep in the ocean where corals grow and colorful fish swim. Some mermaids are blessed with amazing voices and sing enchanting songs. In Denmark, there is a bronze statue of the little mermaid by the shore. It is a tribute to Hans Christian Andersen - a famous writer who created The Little Mermaid story. I love mermaids because they are the only magical creature I know that live in the sea.

Phoenix

By Ben Leotis

A phoenix is a magnificent firebird. It has red, gold, and purple feathers and a beautiful song. It is said to be very big and strong. The most magical thing about the phoenix is at the end of its life, it bursts into flames, and a new phoenix is born from the ashes.

The phoenix was an important part of ancient Egyptian and Greek stories. Herodotus, the ancient Greek historian, was the first person to write about the phoenix and said each one lived for 500 years. Even today, the phoenix is used in many stories and art.

Dragon

By Jorge Gabriel Escobar

Dragons are magical creatures with big wings and long tails. They can fly high in the sky and breathe fire. Some dragons guard treasure in caves. My favorite dragon would be red and friendly. I wish I could ride on his back and explore the mountains!

I wish I had a dragon that could turn invisible. We would fly to the moon and eat star-shaped cookies. He would sleep in my tree house and snore little rainbows. When I felt sad, he would make funny faces. I would name him Cash!

Pegasus

Grace Tappis

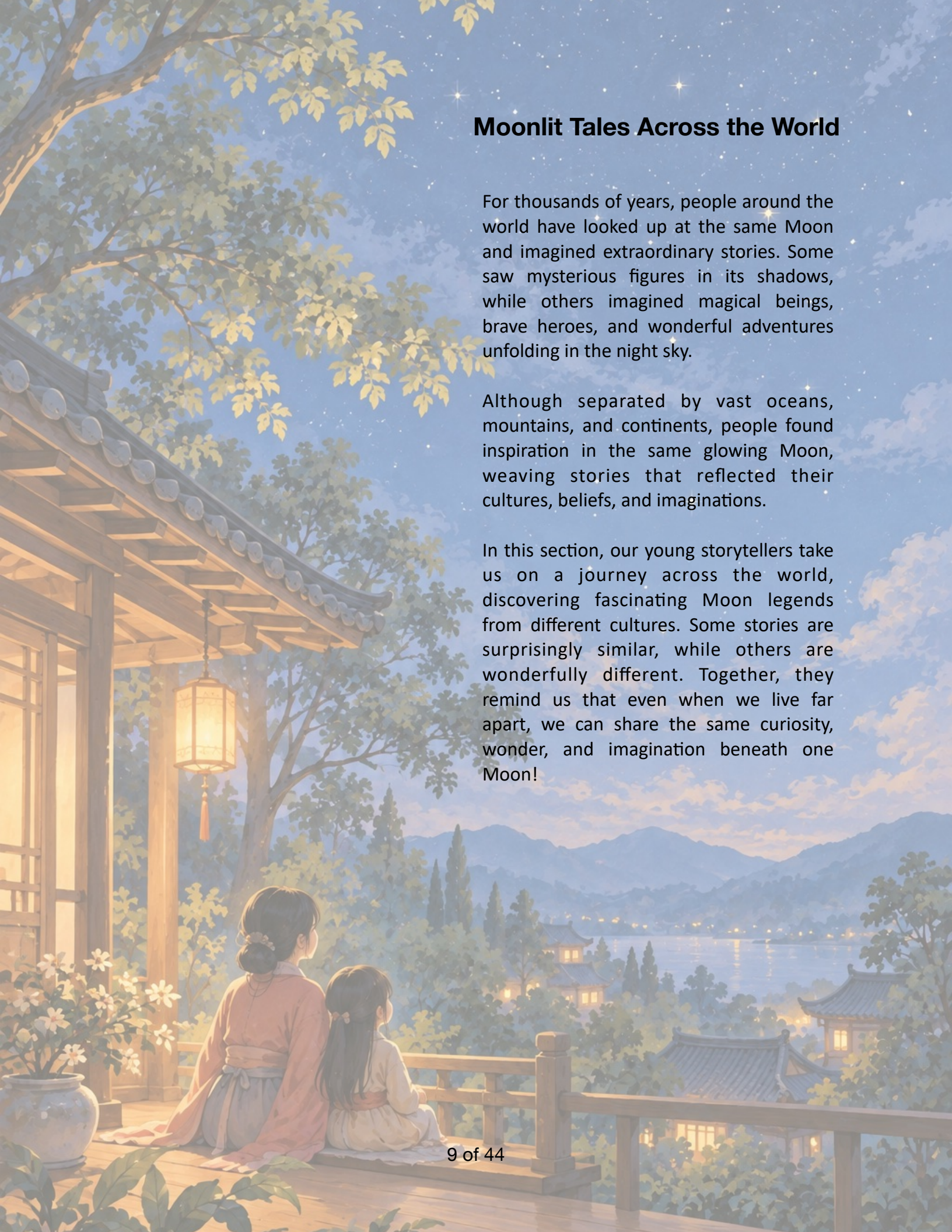
Pegasus is a magical horse with big wings that can fly faster than the wind. He was born from the sea and loved to zoom through the sky. He carried the thunder and lightning bolts Zeus.

Today we can find him in the sky in the pegasus star constellation.

Unicorn

Elle Cristy

A unicorn is a mystical creature because she has a horn. They are special because they are glittery. Unicorns play with other Unicorns. Unicorns are nice. People love unicorns because they are magical. Unicorns are fancy.



Moonlit Tales Across the World

For thousands of years, people around the world have looked up at the same Moon and imagined extraordinary stories. Some saw mysterious figures in its shadows, while others imagined magical beings, brave heroes, and wonderful adventures unfolding in the night sky.

Although separated by vast oceans, mountains, and continents, people found inspiration in the same glowing Moon, weaving stories that reflected their cultures, beliefs, and imaginations.

In this section, our young storytellers take us on a journey across the world, discovering fascinating Moon legends from different cultures. Some stories are surprisingly similar, while others are wonderfully different. Together, they remind us that even when we live far apart, we can share the same curiosity, wonder, and imagination beneath one Moon!

Chandra and His Curse (India)

By Saranya Das

The moon, Chandra, had married twenty seven daughters of Daksha. But he loved Rohini the most among all his other wives and returned to her again and again, leaving the other wives neglected.

His wives' father, Daksha, warned Chandra, the moon, to treat all his daughters equally, but Chandra ignored him. So Daksha cursed him to waste away and lose his light.

As Chandra faded, the world started to suffer and the gods begged Daksha to show mercy. Daksha couldn't completely take back his curse but had agreed to soften it.

From that day on, Chandra would fade for part of each month and then slowly regain his light, waning and waxing in an endless cycle.

Ancient India's Careful Observations of Astronomy Hidden in the Story

Why 27?

Chandra's 27 wives are not a random number in the story. Ancient Indian astronomers divided the Moon's path across the sky into 27 regions. The Moon takes about 27.3 days to complete one orbit around Earth relative to the background stars.

Who is Rohini?

In the night sky, Rohini is a bright, reddish-orange star, also known as Aldebaran. Ancient Indian astronomers noticed how the Moon passed close to this beautiful star again and again. Perhaps that's why Rohini was depicted as Chandra's favorite!

A Deeper Meaning Hidden in the Story

The Moon grows brighter, slowly fades, and then shines again. This endless cycle reminds us that change is a natural part of life. Happiness and sadness, growth and decline, beginnings and endings are all part of our life's journey.

The Girl with a Water Container

By Pavel Steshenko

When I look at the Moon, I can see dark spots. A long time ago, people looked at these spots, imagined very similar things and came up with different stories. I learned two such stories from places that are very far apart - one from the Māori people of New Zealand and the other one is from the Sakha (Yakut) people of Siberia.

🌙 Rona and the Moon — New Zealand

One night, a girl named Rona went to get water. The Moon hid behind the clouds, and Rona fell down. She got angry and yelled at the Moon. The Moon didn't like that and started pulling her into the sky. Rona grabbed a tree, but the Moon was too strong and took Rona, the tree, and her water jug.

🌙 The Gentle Rescue — Siberia

There was a girl among Yakut people who had no parents. People treated her badly and made her work very hard. One night, they sent her to get water. She looked at the Moon and wished it would take her away. The Moon heard her wish and took her into the sky with her water buckets.

I noticed that both stories have girls carrying water, and the Moon takes both of them into the sky. But there is a strange difference. Rona struggles to stay on Earth, while the orphan girl is rescued from it. In one story, the Moon is angry. In the other, it is kind.

How did people living so far away imagine such similar stories? Did they look at the same dark patches on the Moon and see the same shapes? Or is there another mystery hiding in these ancient tales? Maybe the Moon whispered the same story to both!

Fun Fact:
When I look closely at the Moon, I can see a puppy!

The Rabbit on the Moon

Have you ever looked closely at the Moon and noticed its dark patches? People around the world have been looking at those same mysterious markings for thousands of years. And here's something extraordinary — in many different cultures, people imagined seeing a **rabbit on the Moon!**

Did You Know?

The rabbit on the moon has many stories! In an ancient Chinese legend, a beautiful woman named Chang'e drinks a magical potion of immortality and floats up to the Moon, where she lives with a special companion — the Jade Rabbit (*Yutu*). The rabbit spends its time grinding magical herbs!

Over many centuries, stories of the Moon Rabbit also became popular in Japan and Korea, but with an interesting twist! In Japan, people imagine the rabbit pounding sticky rice to make *mochi*, a delicious rice cake. In Korea, the rabbit is also busy making rice cakes called *tteok*!

Now let's travel to two places thousands of miles apart — India and Mexico. Both have stories about a rabbit whose extraordinary kindness earned it a place on the Moon.

🇮🇳 **A Hare Who Gave Everything: A Buddhist story from Ancient India**

An ancient Buddhist story from India tells of a hare who wanted to help anyone who was hungry. One day, a hungry stranger appeared. The hare had no food suitable for him, so he offered the only thing he had—himself. He leapt into a fire, but amazingly, the flames did not burn him. The stranger was actually a heavenly king in disguise, who had been testing the hare. Moved by such extraordinary generosity, the king placed the hare's image on the Moon so that his kindness would never be forgotten.

🇲🇽 **A Rabbit Who Made the Same Choice: A popular folklore from Mexico**

Thousands of miles away, a Mexican legend tells of the god Quetzalcoatl, traveling across the land in human form. Tired and hungry, he met a rabbit who offered him grass. When Quetzalcoatl could not eat it, the rabbit realized that he had nothing else to give. So he offered himself. Quetzalcoatl did not accept the sacrifice. Instead, moved by the little rabbit's generosity, he raised him toward the Moon so that his image appeared there. Although the rabbit was small, Quetzalcoatl told him that his kindness would be remembered.

When our young contributors read these stories, they noticed something fascinating. How could people living so far apart imagine such similar tales? What do these stories tell us about the things people value? On the next page, our young thinkers share their own observations, comparisons, and questions about these two remarkable stories.

Two Rabbits, Two Distant Lands

By Emma Broder with contributions from Freya Knuffman

Two distant lands, two ancient legends, and one extraordinary act of kindness

India and Mexico are on opposite sides of the world, about 9,000 miles apart! Yet both places have an ancient story about a rabbit whose kindness was so extraordinary that it was remembered on the Moon. The story from India has been told for about 2,000 years! The Mexican folktale is only about 1,000 years old, but that is still a very long time for stories to have been talked about. In the first story the rabbit leaps into the fire to provide food for a heavenly king, but in the second story rabbit offers himself to an ancient god named Quetzalcoatl. When you read one story and it reminds you of something else, it can affect how you think about both stories.

A Kindness Worth Remembering

I think that the people wanted the rabbit to be remembered for his kindness and generosity. The rabbit was going to sacrifice himself for another being which is a very brave and generous thing to do. People wanted the rabbit to be remembered for a kind act and not let that be forgotten.

How Could Two Stories Be So Similar?

We think it is amazing that people living thousands of miles apart imagined such similar stories! There are many ways two very similar stories could have come from places on opposite sides of the globe. One of the ways is that if people were traveling between countries, they could have settled in other places and then told stories to everyone else and those stories would have been carried down. Obviously the stories would have been a little different because everyone remembers things differently. I think it is very cool that there can be thousands of year old stories from completely different places that share so many characteristics. I wonder if there are any other stories from other places in the world that share similar stories, and what those stories are about!

Recent Discovery: Beyond Human Imagination

By Aadrita Chattopadhyay

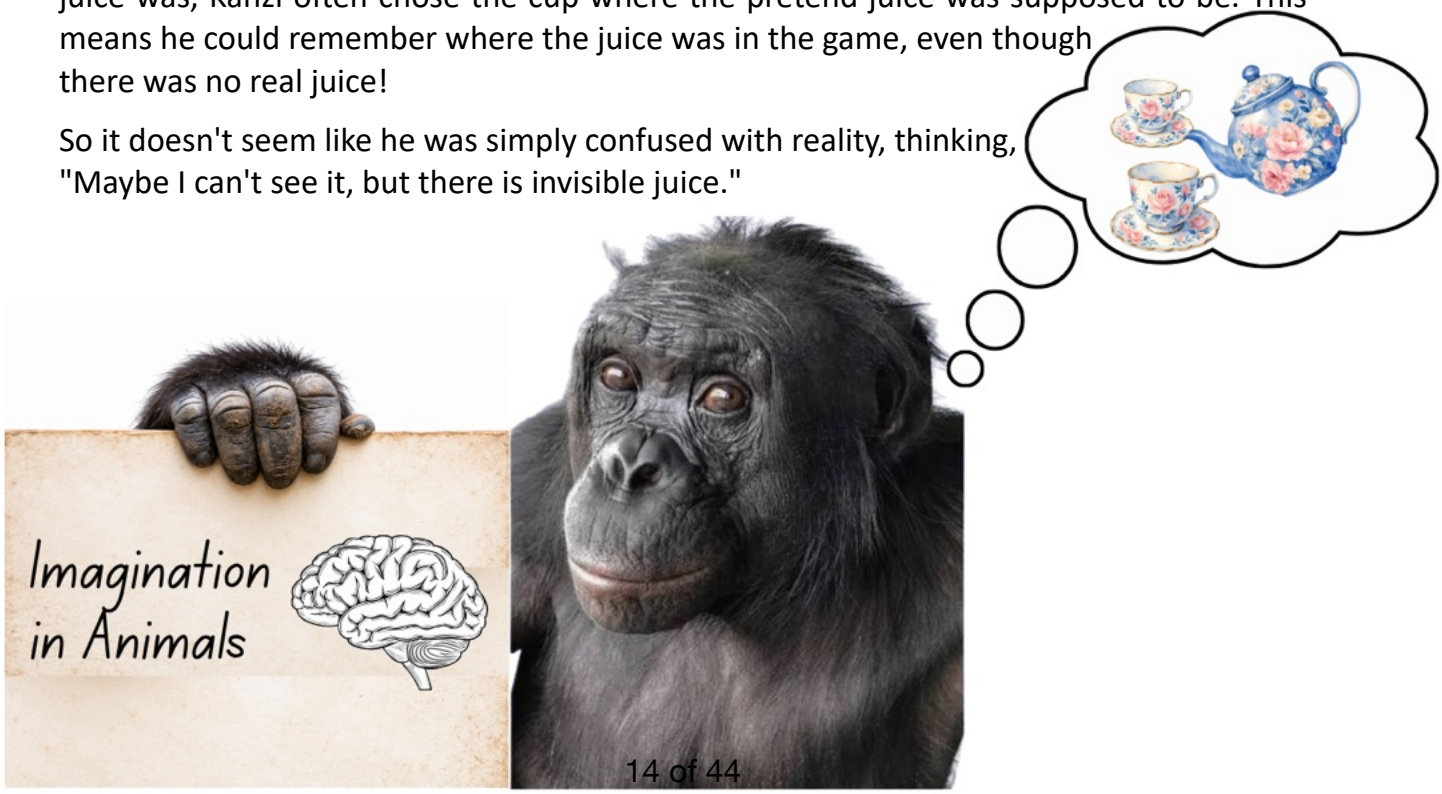
I love playing pretend games. Sometimes I pretend that I am a paleontologist! I get to dig up the fossils, and then tell the scientists that we found something new, and then we bring the dinosaur fossil back to the lab. I play it in my room. So I don't really dig up anything. I just pretend that the brown floor is dirt. And we went to a desert place, and explore. I just pretend that I'm a paleontologist. Its a very detailed imagination. It's actually my powerful brain that helps me imagine all that. But do you know that we are not the only animals who have this power to imagine things? Other animals may be able to imagine things too!

Earlier this year, two scientists, Dr. Amalia Bastos and Dr. Christopher Krupenye, published a study about a bonobo named Kanzi. They did an experiment to find out if Kanzi could understand pretend things too.

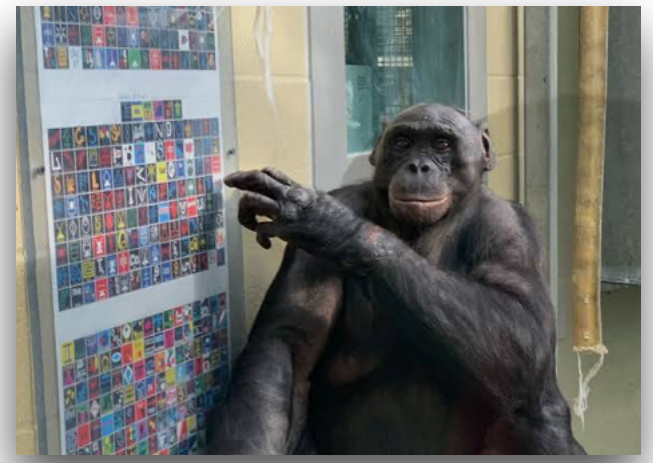
So the scientists put two empty cups in front of Kanzi. They pretended to pour juice into the cups. Then they asked Kanzi where the juice was. And Kanzi often picked the cup with the pretend juice in it!

I think there are two things here to understand. First, Kanzi could see that there was actually no juice being poured, right? It was just make-believe. So he could see what was really happening, but he could also follow what was happening in the pretend game. I think this is something very important. Second, when the scientists asked where the juice was, Kanzi often chose the cup where the pretend juice was supposed to be. This means he could remember where the juice was in the game, even though there was no real juice!

So it doesn't seem like he was simply confused with reality, thinking, "Maybe I can't see it, but there is invisible juice."



The scientists did another test to help check this. Kanzi could tell the difference between real juice and pretend juice. He seemed to understand that there was no real juice, but he could still follow the pretend game. And that is amazing!



Scientists have a special name for keeping two different ideas in our minds — what is real and what is pretend. They call it secondary representation. Scientists have also found clues that some birds and other animals can imagine things that might happen in the future. But I still wonder if they imagine things the same way we do. Our brains are so powerful! A part of our brain called the hippocampus helps us use our memories to imagine things we have never experienced before.

Kanzi died in 2025, but he helped scientists learn many amazing things about the minds of animals.

When I pretend that my bedroom floor is a desert and I am digging up dinosaur fossils, I know I am really in my room. But inside my imagination, I am exploring a whole different world! I wonder what Kanzi imagined inside his mind. And I wonder how many more amazing things are happening inside the minds of animals that we still don't understand!

Kanzi with Dr. Sue Savage-Rumbaugh, a Primatologist and communication specialist.

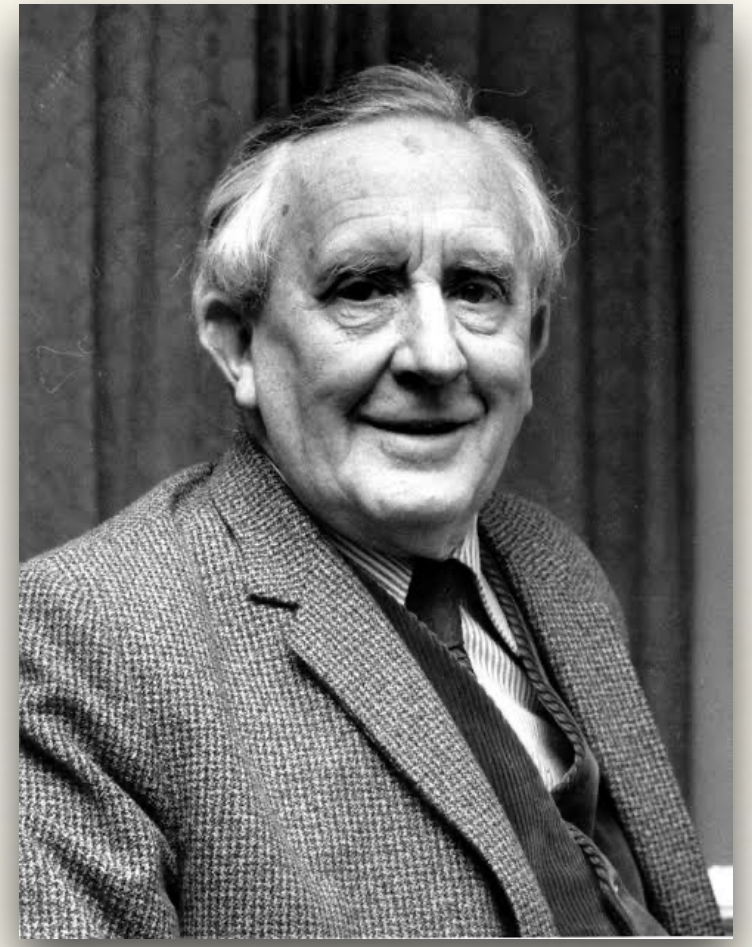
Featured article:
https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/41642999/

Research Communication

Exploring Research Through Collaboration

Research becomes even more exciting when we get to explore it alongside the people who actually do it! In this section, our young writers step into the world of research communication — exploring original research, understanding fascinating ideas, and sharing what they discover with our readers, with guidance and insights from the researchers themselves.

An issue celebrating fairy tales and imagination would be incomplete without acknowledging J. R. R. Tolkien, whose extraordinary imagination brought Middle-earth to life! This month, our young researcher Debashis, together with several fellow young contributors, pays tribute to J. R. R. Tolkien by exploring the remarkable imagination behind his literary world, guided by the fascinating research of Professor Dimitra Fimi at the University of Glasgow.



J.R.R Tolkien

This special collaboration was made possible by Professor Fimi's generous support. We are deeply grateful for the time, care, and encouragement she has given our young writers — thoughtfully reviewing their work, sharing her expertise, and contributing her own insights. Her kindness and enthusiasm have made this a truly meaningful learning experience for the children.

The Timeless Wonder of J. R. R. Tolkien

By Debashis Chakraborty

J. R. R. Tolkien was a famous writer and scholar. He wrote wonderful stories such as The Hobbit, The Lord of the Rings, Roverandom, and Smith of Wootton Major. He also wrote poems, novels and created extraordinary magical world.

J. R. R. Tolkien did something even more amazing. He created an entire imaginary world called Middle-earth, with its own history, maps, peoples, and languages! But that can't be easy to imagine, right? I wonder where all these extraordinary ideas came from?

Professor Dimitra Fimi, a scholar who studies Tolkien's writings at the University of Glasgow in Scotland, explored this fascinating question too. Her research shows how different stories, paintings, and ancient traditions helped shape Tolkien's imagination.

For example, Tolkien watched a stage performance of Peter Pan in 1910. Professor Fimi explores connections between the fairies in stories like Peter Pan, the beautiful Victorian fairy paintings of artists such as Richard Doyle, and the fairy-like creatures appearing in Tolkien's early writings.

In his poem "Goblin Feet", Tolkien wrote about tiny magical creatures like leprechauns, gnomes, and goblins. They danced, made music, and carried little glowing lights. I wonder how did they all look in Tolkien's mind? Professor Fimi noticed that these creatures were much like the little fairies seen in paintings and stories during Tolkien's time. Perhaps these helped inspire his magical world!

Tolkien was also fascinated by ancient European languages and legends. He studied Norse mythology, Germanic traditions, and knew so many Celtic stories. These traditions offered inspiration for the extraordinary beings in his imaginary world.

Think about his elves! Unlike the tiny winged fairies we often see in children's books, Tolkien's elves were generally as tall as humans. They were beautiful, wise, extraordinarily long-lived, and sometimes powerful warriors. They had their own languages, kingdoms, histories, and adventures.

But what amazes me most is how Tolkien brought all these ideas together to create a world that feels almost real! He went to extraordinary lengths to add even the smallest details, so that readers could imagine themselves living in Middle-earth. Sometimes, while reading his stories, it almost feels as though the line between the real world and the imaginary world has disappeared!

Think about languages. The languages we speak today have developed over thousands of years, with countless people contributing to and changing them. But Tolkien, who was himself an excellent scholar of languages, invented entire languages for his imaginary world! He developed Elvish languages with their own grammar, sounds, vocabulary, and writing systems. Isn't it extraordinary that one person could imagine so much?

I find Tolkien's creativity, imagination, and dedication truly inspiring.

Professor Fimi's research helped us discover something wonderful: even the most imaginative writers find inspiration in stories, art, and traditions that came before them and they take these ideas and transform them into something new.

A SCHOLAR'S PERSPECTIVE

How Tolkien Made an Imaginary World Feel Real

A special reflection by Professor Dimitra Fimi

Professor of Fantasy and Children's Literature,
University of Glasgow

This is a lovely summary of Tolkien's achievement, both as a scholar and as a creative writer. I should also add that Tolkien was a pretty skilled artist too: he drew, painted and designed the iconic cover of The Hobbit (for which he also created numerous illustrations) and he used sketching and drawing to visualize the world of Middle-earth as he was creating it. He drew landscapes, architectural details, and, famously, created maps of Middle-earth, giving readers a sense that this world is real, charted, and scaled. When the hobbits walk for hours or even for days, the reader can follow their journey on the map and the length of their journey is correctly calculated to correspond to the distances represented on the map. He also created new writing systems for his Elvish languages – the best known example is the flowing script that can be seen on the One Ring in The Lord of the Rings. My research began because of the feeling of immersion into Middle-earth and Tolkien's gift in creating the illusion of a world that is imaginary, yet feels real.

Beyond the Stories: Discovering Folklore with Prof. Zhang

What happens when ancient Chinese folklore meets the curiosity of young minds? We had the wonderful opportunity to explore the fascinating world of Chinese myths, legends, and traditions with Professor Lijun Zhang, an expert in Chinese folklore in George Mason University! This interview was led by our little interviewer, Chloe, whose curiosity and thoughtful questions helped guide the conversation with Prof. Zhang.

What makes this interview even more special is that Professor Zhang collaborated with her 10-year-old daughter, Anna Yuan, who brought her own knowledge, curiosity, and experiences from fieldwork trips to China into the conversation. Together, this remarkable mother-daughter team helped bring these fascinating stories to life for our young readers.

We are delighted to share this wonderful conversation with you!

1. Who told the very first fairy tale? What do you think?

We don't know who told the first fairy tale. However, we do know that storytelling has always been an important part of human history. In fact, people were telling stories long before written languages were invented. Rock paintings were one of the ways early humans recorded stories and evidence of early storytelling.

2. What if somebody forgot part of a story and just made something up? Would the made-up part eventually become part of the real story?

Storytelling is a communal process that involves many story tellers and audience of different backgrounds. Each story is often slightly changed by the person telling it. This means that the stories we know today are almost certainly not the originals, even if they remain similar.

3. Do you think there are wonderful old stories that have completely disappeared because nobody remembered them?

Stories depend on the communities that preserve and share them, and if those communities stop telling the stories or change so much that they can no longer sustain the practice of storytelling, the stories are likely lost to time.

4. If two countries have almost the same story, how do you figure out whether the story travelled between them or whether both people thought of it separately?

In the earlier history of folklore studies, folklorists tried to trace stories to their origins, but that is no longer common practice. This is because finding the true origin of a story is almost impossible. Take Cinderella as an example, there are more than 300 variants of it around the world. One of the earliest variant "Yexian" was recorded in China in 9th century. But the story has been orally shared before it was written down. The many variants show a universal pattern while also reflecting specific social, cultural, and historical contexts.

5. Why do people change stories instead of keeping them exactly the same?

The stories changed because the circumstances were different each time they were told. For example, before publishing the stories they collected, the Brothers Grimm removed and rewrite many scenes, such as the more violent ones, so they would be more suitable for young audiences.

6. Mushu is one of the funniest characters in Mulan. But if he wasn't in the original story, how is he part of Mulan's story now?

The people involved in producing the movie were the ones who decided to include Mushu in the story. As far as I know, the original story of Mulan is a poetic narrative of fewer than 400 words. In that case, it would have been almost impossible for Disney not to add extra details when adapting it into a 1.5-hour movie. And Mushu is one of the things that they added.

7. If Disney changes an old story and millions more people know the Disney version than the old one, can the new version eventually replace the old story?

It depends. Take Mulan as an example, in the United States, most people may know only the Disney version. In China, however, most people are familiar with both the original poetic version of Mulan and its adapted versions.

8. If I watch Mulan and assume what ancient China was like, could I get things wrong?

We can learn something about ancient China by watching Mulan, but it does not present the whole picture. The film depicts only one region of China during a specific historical period, whereas China in reality has diverse cultures and a very long, dynamic history.

9. We read the story you told about the Butterfly lovers. It is so sad that it makes me cry. Did you also cry the first time you read it?

I was also deeply touched by the story. At the same time, it is inspiring because it shows a girl who is not afraid to challenge the rules for what she believes is right.

10. When you arrive somewhere to study people's traditions, who do you talk to first? What do you pay attention to?

For folklorists, the first people they often contact are “tradition bearers,” who are active practitioners of a community’s culture, such as folk singers, storytellers, and craftspeople. But we can also learn from everyone else in the community.

11. You can put an old basket or dress in a museum. But how do you put a story in a museum?

There are many ways to do this. For example, you can write the story down on a text panel. You can also record someone telling the story in audio or video form. You can have people perform the story in a museum. For stories preserved in rock paintings, you can display an image of the painting. Hmong immigrant communities in the United States also create embroidered story cloths to share their experience and stories, and these works can be displayed in a museum.

12. What is the strangest creature you have ever found in a folk tale?

The ancient Chinese story text Classic of Mountains and Seas features numerous strange creatures, which I found fascinating. For instance, there is a gluttonous beast named Taotie, which has a goat’s body, a human face, eyes in its armpits, human hands, and an enormous appetite.

13. Is there a Chinese fairy-tale character you wish Disney would make a movie about?

There are many interesting characters in Chinese folktales. As for me, it would be interesting if Disney made a movie based on Classic of Mountains and Seas. When I asked the Chinese students in my class, they said they are very interested in the myth of Chang’e (the Goddess of the Moon) and Wukong (Monkey King in Journey to the West).

14. Why are girls so often princesses in the fairy tales we know? Did people in the past have different ideas about what girls should be like?

In the past, when these stories were developed and orally shared, people, especially women and girls, often had limited choices and little social power. As a result, becoming a princess could be imagined as one of the best possible outcomes for a girl. However, this idea is largely symbolic. It symbolizes that the heroine’s suffering has ended and that she will now live a safe, respected, prosperous, and happy life. In this way, it reflects the storytellers’ wishes and hopes for a better life.

15. Do children in China hear the same bedtime stories as children in America?

Children in China hear both stories from China such as the stories of Chang'e and Wukong that I mentioned earlier, and stories that are read to children in America such as Little Red Riding Hood. Sometimes they hear versions recorded by the Brothers Grimm, and sometimes they hear the Chinese variants such as "Lang Popo (Wolf Grandma)."

16. In many fairy tales, we meet very rich people, like kings and princesses, or very poor people who have almost nothing. We don't seem to meet as many people in between. Today, lots of families are neither very rich nor very poor. Was society different when these old stories were first told, or is there another reason fairy tales are like this?

Fairy tales rely heavily on formulaic, patterned expressions, which are a major feature of oral storytelling. The characters in fairy tales are often two-dimensional, standing at opposite ends of an attribute scale. They are either very rich or very poor, very kind or very bad, very beautiful or very ugly.

Professor Lijun Zhang with her lovely daughter Anna Yuan at the pottery and ceramic ancient town Jingdezhen in China.

17. If you could go inside one folk tale for one day, which one would you choose—and why?

I would go inside Classic of Mountains and Seas because then I could see all the interesting mythical creatures.

Creativity
Corner

Beyond the Pages: In Conversation with Lulu Delacre

What a wonderful adventure it has been for our young readers to explore the colorful world of Lulu Delacre's books! An award-winning author and illustrator, Lulu has brought more than 40 books to life, earned three prestigious Pura Belpré Honors, and illustrated the New York Times bestseller Turning Pages by Justice Sonia Sotomayor. Her beautiful stories and illustrations celebrate imagination, culture, and the joy of discovery. We are deeply grateful to Lulu for giving them this incredible opportunity to connect with such an accomplished and inspiring storyteller and artist!

If you are interested about Lulu Delacre's work, please check out her website for all her creativity, accomplishments and latest news: https://www.luludelacre.com/

🌱 *Memories, Places & Inspiration*

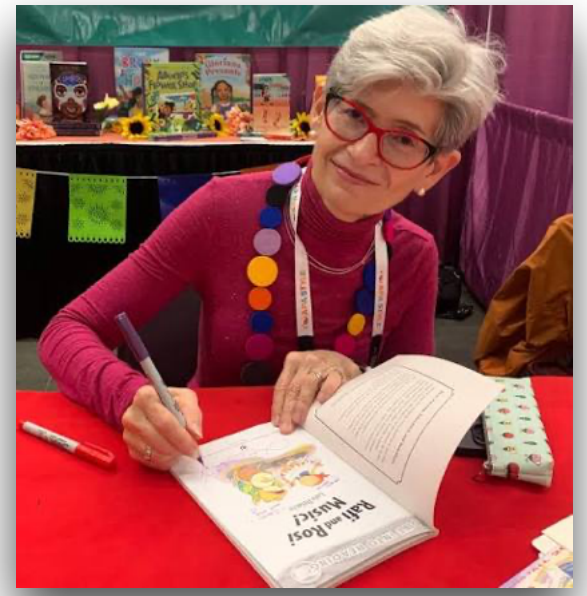
1. We read that you grew up in Puerto Rico, climbing tamarind trees and catching little lizards. How much of the world you create in your books comes from things you actually saw and did as a child?

The island imprinted in me memories and feelings that permeate my work. Sometimes I consciously do it, sometimes it comes about inadvertently. The books that celebrate my latino heritage have a little of Puerto Rico in them. I cherish the opportunity to showcase the culture.

2. You took your first formal painting classes while living in Buenos Aires. Do you remember anything from that time that changed the way you looked at the world - or the way you drew it?

I remember being a young child taking drawing classes meant for adults. That marked me. My teacher noticed how serious I was as I drew from the model. And she treated me as an adult. She expected of me quality work. And I thrived being recognized and encouraged in that way.

3. We read that your grandmother Elena encouraged you to draw and carefully saved your pictures. How did she influence the artist you eventually became?
I can't recall my grandma ever praising my drawings. She was strict and in her ways. The discovery that she had never thrown away a drawing of mine, made me realize that, for her, they were worth keeping. It gave me confidence.



4. When we read Cool Green, we wondered, "How does Lulu know all of this about trees?" Did you already know a lot about trees, or did you learn much of it while researching the book? What discovery about trees surprised you most?
Good question! I've been in love with trees and gardens since I used to help my dad in our small garden in Puerto Rico. At a young age I discovered the beauty of trees. I found the joy climbing them, hiding behind them, and walking or running among them. I wanted to share my love of trees with children, so I thought what would young Lulu like to know? Perhaps, which is the tallest tree in the world? The widest? The most colorful? The most rare? I researched the answers to my questions for months, in books and with scientists. I love learning new things. Distilling them in to a fun full-of-cool-facts non-fiction picture book is a privilege.

✨ From an Idea to a Story

5. Why did you choose Puerto Rico's tiny coquí frogs to become Rafi and Rosi? Was there something about them that made them just right for these characters?
Absolutely! They are ubiquitous in the island. They are tiny, hard to see, but easy to listen to. These tree frogs have a sweet song that lulls all islanders to sleep. Their song envelope all in the nighttime and is loved by all Puerto Ricans. One afternoon, missing my island, I began to draw coqui tree frogs as characters, and Rafi and Rosi were born.

6. Vejigantes are such a colorful part of Rafi and Rosi: Carnival! What did you most want children who have never experienced a Puerto Rican carnival to discover about them through your stories?
The island is rich with traditions that are fun to learn about. I know as a young girl I would have liked to be queen of the carnival. As much as I know it would have been fun to dress as a vejigante. So I imagine, children anywhere could see themselves in these roles as well.

7. We noticed that Rafi often tries to impress Rosi but sometimes ends up upsetting her - and Rosi finds a way to forgive her big brother. Why was this aspect of brother-sister relationship important to you when developing their characters?

Yes. I wanted to portray a true sibling relationship. The back and forth, the ups and downs. And the love. I modeled their relationship in the one between my husband and his sister.

8. In How Far Do You Love Me?, every landscape feels so peaceful and beautiful. Did you visit all those places, or did some come from your imagination? For places you did visit, did you paint them there or later from photographs and memories?

Yes. I have been fortunate enough to visit every place portrayed in the book. That is how I was able to convey the feeling of calm and expansive beauty. I worked from memories and photographs that I took or found later on

9. For How Far Do You Love Me?, did the story come first and inspire the landscapes, or did some of the pictures and places help the story take shape?

The story came about thinking of the game I played with my own daughters when they were young. On a walk around my neighborhood I thought of how much I love my children. How high, how deep, how far. And I began to compose the poem out loud remembering the magnificent places and lands I've been able to visit. By the time I returned home, I had the manuscript.

🎨 *Telling Stories Through Art*

10. We noticed in your gallery that you use many different kinds of art—watercolors, pencil drawings, pastels, collage, and black-and-white work. How do you decide which medium is right for a story? Do different materials help you express different feelings? Is there one you especially love?

Great observation! I let the manuscript dictate the technique. For example, in How Far Do You Love Me? I wanted to work with dry pastel, its soft, rich, and conveys the beauty I was seeking. I don't have a favorite, although lately, I'm having lots of fun with collage.

11. We noticed that many of your pictures show a child close to a parent—being loved, protected, or shown something beautiful about the world. Does that come from how you experienced the world as a child, how you shared it with your own children, or perhaps both?

It may come of how I shared the world with my own children, and how I share it with any child that reads my books. I truly believe every child is a diamond in the raw, you just have to shower a child with love to see the seed grow and bloom.

12. We noticed that shadows sometimes seem to have a meaning of their own in your illustrations. Do you use shadows deliberately to tell us something that the words don't?

You may be referring to Luci Soars. In the story a young girl, is born without a shadow, and discovers that by changing the way she looks at things, the things she looks at change.

13. As both a writer and an illustrator, do you find it easier to capture a story's feelings when you illustrate your own words? What is different when you bring someone else's story to life?

There is a lot of research involved when I illustrate someone else's work. As I try not only to capture the author's intent, but add enriching layers to the story. It's easier for me when I illustrate my own words.

🌎 Stories, Culture & the Reader

14. Your books often celebrate culture and heritage. What do you think can be hardest for children growing up far from their extended families? How can stories help them stay connected to that part of themselves?

Your roots ground you. So keeping the heritage of your family alive in foods you eat, traditions you keep, a different language, is key to empowering you as a full individual. You are richer by having two languages, and two cultures. Reading books about the place of your family's origin can expand your knowledge. It helps you understand things that may be hard to understand otherwise.

15. You have lived in many parts of the world - Puerto Rico, Argentina, France, and now the United States. How has living among different cultures shaped the way you see people and the world? Has it made you more aware of what makes each culture unique, or of the things that connect us despite our differences?

Absolutely! The world is full of different and fascinating cultures. Every culture has its beauty, and getting to know a little bit about them, even if only through books, opens up your world. You become understanding & emphatic. And that is key if we want to live in a world where we are connected by the same yearnings of home, family, and a peaceful life.

Book Review

Unicorn Diaries By Rebecca Elliott

By Aadrita Chattopadhyay

Unicorn Diaries is a delightful series of children's books filled with magic, friendship and adventures. Each book beautifully reminds us that kindness and friendship are among the greatest gifts we can share.

The stories follow Bo Tinseltail, a cheerful little unicorn who lives in Sparkle Grove forest. Bo has many friends and they go to a magical school. Each unicorn there has a special power - Bo's is granting wishes every week.

Each book takes the unicorns to a new adventure. They meet new creatures, solve mysteries, discover unexplored places, help each other. They always manage to achieve what others might have thought impossible.

This is an excellent series of books for anyone who loves magic, enjoys stories about kindness, friendship, bravery, teamwork - together turning the impossible to possible. The author, Rebecca Elliott, is also the illustrator of the books. Her colorful drawings make you feel like you are in an enchanted world.

The Magic Behind Animation: In Conversation with Prof.Wells

We were incredibly fortunate to have a fascinating conversation with the amazing Professor Paul Wells, an internationally renowned expert in animation! From bringing drawings to life to creating unforgettable characters and magical worlds, he shared wonderful insights into the art of animation. His thoughtful answers, personal stories, and enthusiasm made this an unforgettable experience for our young interviewers.
Here, we share a few highlights from our conversation. The full interview, with many more fascinating questions and answers, is available on our website!

1. When I draw a character on paper, it just sits there. How do animators make drawings come alive?

One way of thinking about an answer to this question is to think about an exercise animators at Pixar were asked to do. Simply, they were given some source photographs that the American painter and illustrator Norman Rockwell used for some of his work, and asked how Rockwell had moved from the realism of the photos to the 'caricature' of the images he created. This was done simply through exaggerating to some degree each aspect of a figure – eyes were wider, smiles were bigger, arms were extended, gestures made larger, bodies made plumper or thinner etc. This moved the characters beyond naturalism and made them more like a cartoon. The most important aspect of this approach though is that the characters must 'do' something, however small or big, to make an implied movement have an aspect of storytelling – winking, staring, waving, making a sandwich, pulling the curtains etc. So, the combination of exaggerated motion with movement that implies a narrative, again however small, ensures a sense of a character coming alive.

2. In Frozen, Elsa creates an entire ice palace while singing. How do animators make a scene feel so magical that we almost forget it is impossible?

Human beings love spectacle and performances that seem larger than life. The more something makes you go 'wow, how did they do that ?', the more you have a feeling of wonder that takes your feelings beyond those you might experience in everyday life to a place that you rarely experience so it becomes magical and memorable. Some people call this feeling 'the sublime', The excess and seeming impossibility of what you are seeing carries you along because in animation IT IS POSSIBLE !! That's what makes the form so special and so significant because it can transport people into situations and spectacular places they never experience. (Don't forget all the Marvel movies, Star Wars etc have lots of animation that makes this happen, it's just more realistic animation than Pixar or Disney style cartoons).

3. Sometimes cartoon characters fall from cliffs and walk away unharmed. Why do we accept things in cartoons that are impossible in real life?

Simply, animation is always telling the viewer that it is NOT recorded reality but created reality as it might be depicted through drawing, puppets, clay, computer images, and lots of other materials. Animation is always telling us it is an illusion, and though we might 'believe' in the characters and their environment, it does not disguise that it has been made. This re-assures the audience because they know that all non-realistic actions and depictions are imaginative and fantastical at some level, and not naturalistic. This means the action can be plausible as comedy, magic, fantasy, thoughts, dreams, etc but is never realistic in an everyday life sort-of-way. Don't forget animation can defy all the laws of the physical world and depict impossible action as its unique language, so it provides a different model of creativity for animators, practitioners and writers.

4. Why do so many cartoon animals talk, wear clothes, and behave like humans?

This was a question I asked myself many years ago when I wrote a book called 'The Animated Bestiary'. Why do so many animated films from all over the world, for over a century of production, feature animals? There are many answers to this question but the main one is that it is often much easier for human beings to express ideas about what it is to be human by not representing themselves as human. By being 'an animal' this often gets around issues of race, religion, identity, or even familiarity etc, and allows animators either to construct their characters with some degree of 'innocence' or the very opposite – they can smuggle through ideas that might be opposed, or not permitted in certain countries, or simply which are complex but which can be expressed symbolically or as a metaphor when represented as an animal. Animals have a long history of meanings in fables and fairytales so animation often draws on that too. The expression of human characteristics in animals, objects, environments etc is called anthropomorphism, and though some people criticize its use, it really does help in both being appealing to viewers (particularly children) but also representing issues and ideas. Have a look at my book if you can – your teacher might be able to use some of it to help you understand these ideas more.

5. Tom and Jerry hardly ever speak, but they make us laugh so much. How can a cartoon be funny without words?

This is normally about the dramatic or comic action – Tom and Jerry use lots of comic violence; the Roadrunner uses endless chases; Bugs Bunny uses lots of verbal wit; all TEX AVERY cartoons use mad, surreal visual gags etc. But even going back to Felix the Cat he uses visual puns where one object looks like another and enables the animator to create a visual joke. My book Understanding Animation has lots on comedy in animation which your teacher might be able to help you with. Also Frank Thomas and Ollie Johnson, two of the original Disney animators in the book 'The Illusion of Life' explain all of Disney's approach to visual jokes.

6. In Inside Out, Joy and Sadness are feelings, but they look and behave like people. How do animators turn invisible feelings into characters?

This is one of the most special characteristics of animation. The animator can give form and character to an invisible concept, or simply something we can't see, like an interior of something, or even a state of mind. Animation is great at dreams, memories, thoughts and fantasies in the mind. It is brilliant at showing us how something works. And it is especially good at taking a concept (joy, anger etc) or an element (water, wind etc) and giving it a personality by virtue of two things. Its associations (Sad is blue, slow because it's depressed, philosophic because it's resigned, etc) and its established color and movement codes (Anger is red, connected with fire raging, suggestive of blood coursing, etc). Once the associations and motion possibilities are considered it is comparatively straightforward to develop the character because the design and movements are established.

7. When you were little, was there a cartoon that made you wonder, "How did they do that?" Do you still feel that wonder today?

I remember vividly puppet animations like Bagpuss and Pogles Wood in the UK because they moved but had no obvious strings like The Woodentops, or later, Thunderbirds. In my own play I realized that you could make certain toys in particular ways to make them stand up or sit down, or make arm gestures, but I was baffled about how they might come to life and move on their own. I wondered about cartoons as well - British ones like Mr Benn or Captain Pugwash, or Mole, which I later found out was from what is now Czechia, and even Tom & Jerry, or Bugs. What even is that ? How is it done ? Then I read 'an interview' with Bugs Bunny in Film Review when I was a young boy. It implied people drew him and made him move. My mum then took me to the library and I found a book on making animated films. I read it from cover to cover and finally found out how Bagpuss, Bugs and a host of other characters moved. Amazing! And frankly, I still remain amazed to this very day!

8. Have you ever seen an idea that sounded completely silly at first but turned into something wonderful?

I was in Japan working on an exhibition of the British studio Halas & Batchelor, which was being staged at the Studio Ghibli Gallery. It was at the time when the studio was developing Spirited Away. The writer and Director Hayao Miyazaki said he wanted to make a film about a bored and slightly spoilt young girl who was moving to a new home with her parents. To be honest no one felt excited about this description. Trust Miyazaki though to put Chihiro, the little girl, into a surreal and supernatural world full of spirits, echoing many stories in Japanese folklore, as she tries to rescue her parents, who have turned into pigs ! The film addresses many themes including the environment, consumerism and tradition. It is a masterpiece of animation. From little acorns, great oaks grow.

9. If you showed us a cartoon without any words or music, could we still understand the whole story?

Often animators have this very ambition in their minds. If a story can be created purely visually it can be seen all around the world and make sense to anyone whatever their language. Music always helps, of course.

Often animators say that they would like their animation to be like music and prompt understanding and emotion not through sound, but color, shape, form and the use of space and time. Combined, the two languages of image and sound connect with viewers in many different ways, and this can range from experimental films right through to visual storytelling that sometimes resembles the action, pantomime, gesture and performance in live action silent films. As human beings we engage with life through all the senses – animation is very good at directing viewers to look at specific things and make sense of them through either their literal meaning (ie I am drinking something) and / or their associations (ie I might be drinking poison, or medicine, or alcohol etc). It is the same with sound. So, animation nearly always operates at a straightforward level of understanding but also uses symbols and metaphor a great deal.

10. What would you suggest to a child who wants to become an animator?

My suggestion would be to draw, draw and draw some more; make as many 3D things as you can; watch as many different styles of animation as possible, and maybe imitate other design styles in your own drawing; read about how animation and film is made. Use your phone to make simple animations of objects moving and slowly but surely develop stories. Maybe use buttons and coins in stop motion just to get the thrill of making something move. Watch people carefully to see how they move and express themselves. Think about color and shape in all the ways it is used. Go to galleries and read comics and graphic novels. Basically be curious about everything and take every opportunity to create. An overall understanding of all the arts is good, too. Eventually an animator magically emerges!

DIY Projects

The Bremen Musicians: A Sculpture and Balancing Game

By Lucas Vorobyev

Inspired by the fairy tale The Town Musicians of Bremen, this little sculpture became a balancing and stacking game as well!

How to Make My Flower Embroidery 🌸

By Saranya Das

First Step:
Take a magic pen which is meant for embroidery (when you iron the cloth, the ink disappears) and then draw a flower in a circle.
Second Step:
Take a black thread and border the flower and the circle it is inside in. Don't forget to put the thread inside the needle before you border. Oh, I forgot to mention you have to do a chain stitch for the borders.
Third Step:
Take an ochre-yellow shade thread and fill it in the petals. This stitch should be chain stitch.
Fourth Step:
Now take a yellow-colored thread and fill it in the pistil. And the embroidery is finished!

Drawing & Painting

Unicorn Playdate

By Elle Cristy

In Elle's colorful world, three cheerful Pegasi spread their bright blue wings and enjoy some magical fun together! With their rainbow-colored manes, smiling faces, and playful spirit, these wonderful creatures remind us that even the most magical adventures are better with friends!

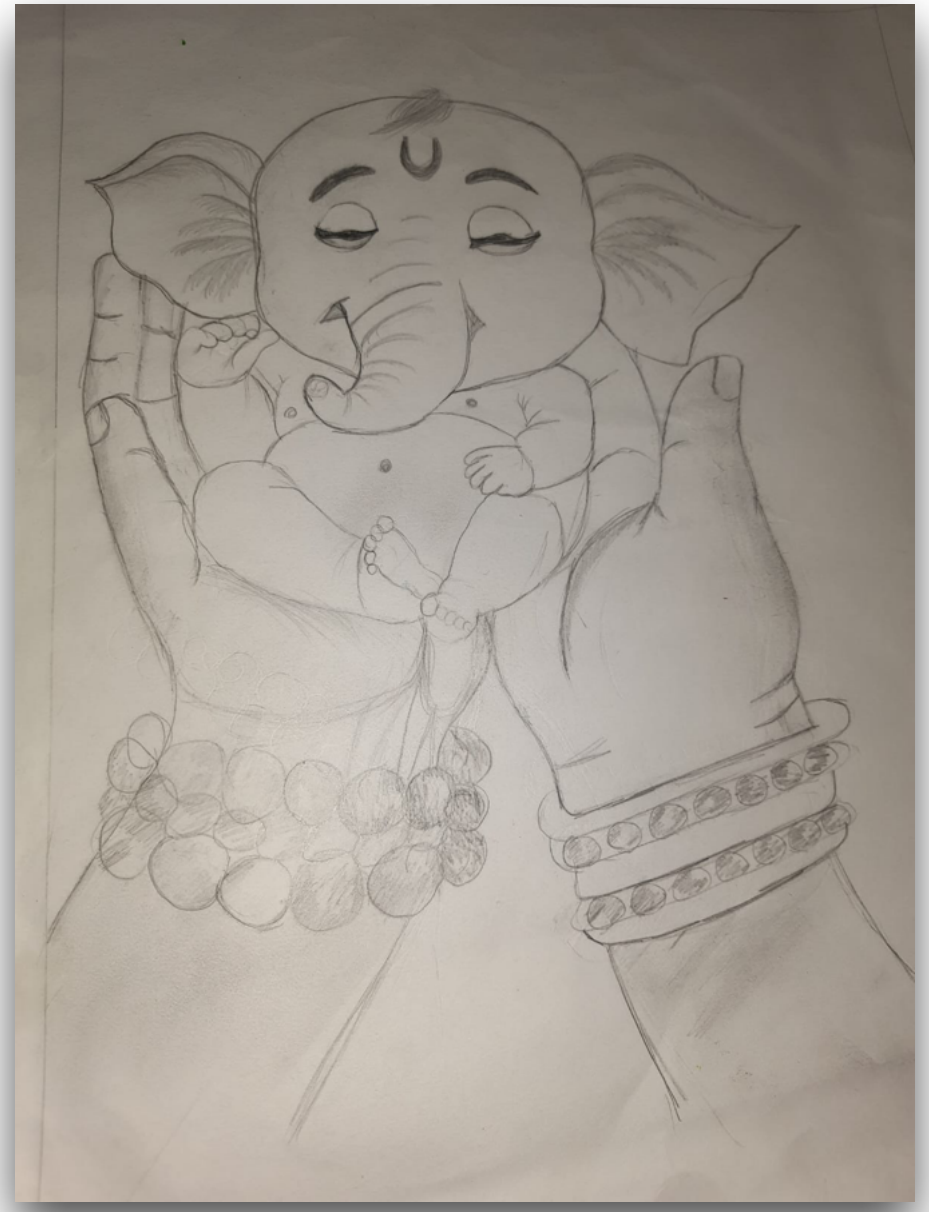
A Pegasus in Blue

By Grace Tappis

With its beautiful blue coat and magnificent wings, Grace created this Pegasus which reminds us that creativity has no rules — and the sky is never the limit when imagination takes flight!

Little Ganesh, Held with Love

By Tishan Ghosh



Cradled gently in loving hands, little Lord Ganesha looks peaceful and adorable in Tishan's beautiful pencil sketch. Through this drawing, Tishan brings together art, imagination, and a beautiful cultural tradition.

Hogwarts: A Dream School

Aarohi Banerjee

Who wouldn't dream of attending a school where staircases move, portraits talk, and magic is part of everyday life? Inspired by the wonderful world of Harry Potter, Aarohi brings Hogwarts to life with glowing windows, magnificent towers, and a mysterious purple night sky. And look closely — there's even a witch flying across the Moon!

For Aarohi, Hogwarts isn't just a castle from a story. It's her dream school, where learning could be a magical adventure every single day!

Fun
Corner

🧩 Word Scramble

Oh no! These words have gotten all jumbled up! Can you rearrange the letters to reveal the hidden words?

S–A–N–T–A–F–Y

C–O–R–I–N–U–N

D–E–R–M–I–A–M

S–E–A–S–P–U–G

T–L–A–E–S–S–C

B–O–L–N–I–G–S

Answers to last issue's word scrambles:
1. CAVE, 2. EARTH, 3. STONE, 4. RUINS, 5. FOSSIL, 6. BURIED, 7. TEMPLE, 8. ANCIENT

🔎 Find the Words

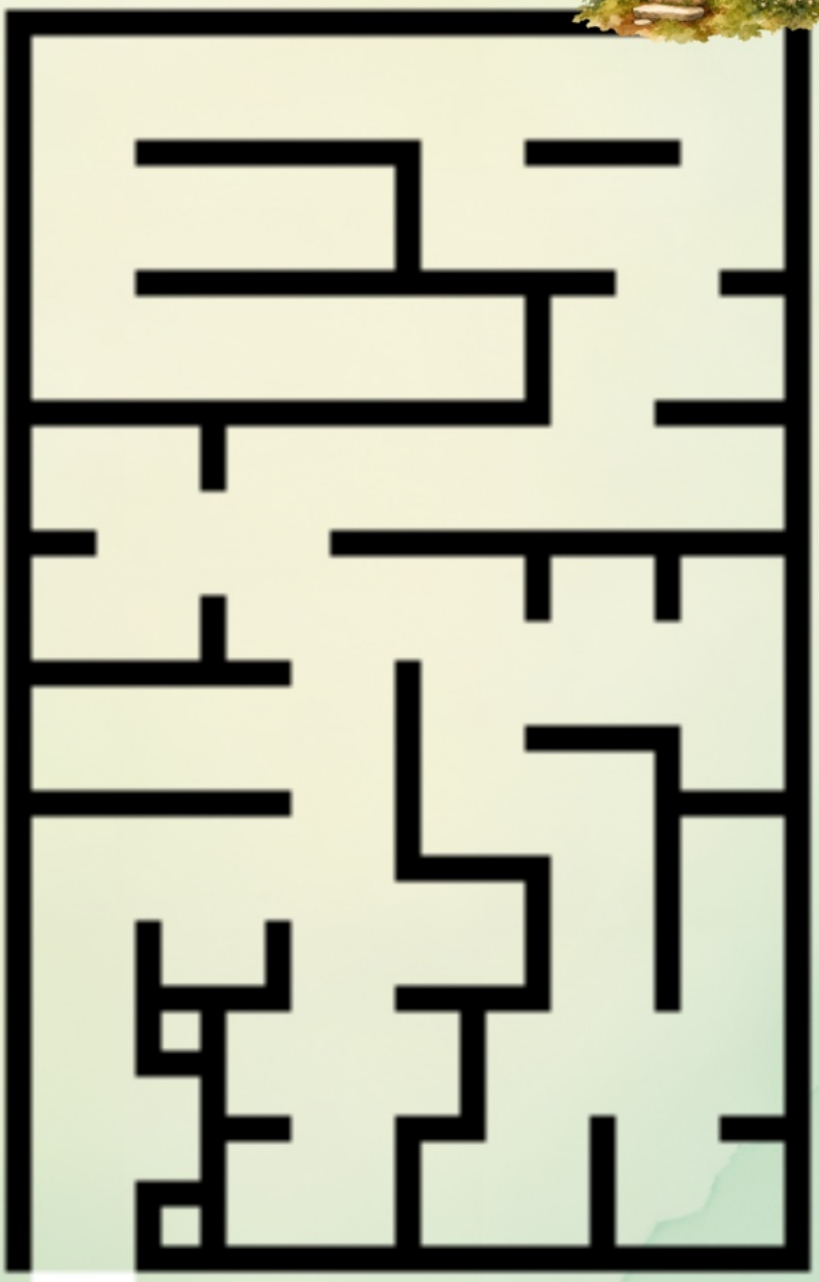
Abracadabra! Ten magical words are hiding in this puzzle! Can you use your sharp eyes to find them all? Look carefully—words may be hidden across or down!

Q	T	W	E	T	R	Y	U	I	O	P	L	G
Z	R	C	W	G	D	R	E	A	N	A	L	O
A	E	N	C	H	A	N	T	E	D	R	F	B
Y	A	W	A	C	X	C	R	Y	S	T	A	L
Q	S	Y	D	P	O	T	I	O	N	I	L	I
Z	U	S	F	H	F	G	T	B	D	O	G	N
S	R	A	I	N	B	O	W	L	R	W	O	P
P	E	Z	D	F	G	H	J	K	E	I	I	U
E	W	S	S	A	X	Q	T	R	A	Z	P	J
L	T	G	K	I	N	G	D	O	M	A	S	K
L	N	M	D	F	G	H	W	U	H	R	L	L
D	K	L	C	L	K	J	X	I	E	D	J	P

1. ENCHANTED
2. TREASURE
3. GOBLIN
4. CRYSTAL
5. KINGDOM
6. DREAM
7. RAINBOW
8. POTION
9. WIZARD
10. SPELL

🍎 Help Snow White Find Her Way Home!

Snow White had a wonderful time playing with her woodland friends, but now it's time to return to her cozy cottage! Can you help Snow White find her way through the maze and get home safely?



👀 Spot the Difference

Something is brewing! A mischievous witch has been practicing her magic, and now five things in her room have mysteriously changed! Can you use your eagle eyes to find all **5 differences** between the two pictures?

Thank You for Reading